the distinct sense that he was preparing for a comeback. He spoke with great passion of how he believed the new government should function. He had parked himself in the national capital hoping for a call-up. It never came. Apparently, Shourie's old enmity with Jaitley had done him in—even in victory, there were still ghosts of a Hindu Divided Family that haunted the BJP.

Also haunting Modi was his own past as an autocratic leader who ran a government in a highly secretive manner. He had governed Gujarat as a virtual one-man show, with an excessively centralized chief minister's office where bureaucrats were often more powerful than ministers. New Delhi is not Gandhinagar—just the scale and dimension of the challenge makes it imperative that the leader empowers the Cabinet and delegates work. But apart from Jaitley and a few others, Modi wasn't convinced about the abilities of many of his Cabinet colleagues. Instead, he wanted to send out a message to the bureaucracy that they would be his prime assets.

A senior bureaucrat who attended a secretaries' meeting with Modi came out most impressed. 'He said he would fully back us for any decision we took, and if there was any problem, we should not hesitate to directly contact him,' the bureaucrat told me. The choice of bureaucrats in Modi's PMO reflected his approach—low-profile and experienced individuals who would never try and overshadow their boss. Many of them were bureaucrats whom Modi had successfully worked with in Gujarat. There was no space in the Modi PMO for a Brajesh Mishra-like figure who was seen by some as the virtual de facto head of government during Vajpayee's tenure.

While the bureaucrats seem satisfied, the ministers clearly are not. First, Modi expects them to work long hours. A minister who was relaxing at home at noon got a sudden wake-up call when a PMO official rang her up and said she was expected to reach office by 9 a.m. every day. Each ministry was asked to put up a detailed presentation before the PMO, listing out their tasks in the first year. 'The days of long lunches for our *mantri*s are over,' was the buzz in Shastri Bhavan. A certain discipline and accountability in ministerial functioning can only be welcomed.